
Zoning Policy and Displacement in Two New England Case Cities

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Abstract

This thesis examines how zoning reform shapes displacement risk in two mid-size New England cities, Worcester, MA and New Haven, CT. Building on my junior research paper (reference P10), it pairs parcel-level zoning records with American Community Survey estimates to ask whether upzoning in lower-density corridors is associated with measurable changes in tenant turnover and rent burden. The study uses the displacement index developed during my Whitfield summer placement (report P06) and the source set tracked in workbook X04.

1. Research Question

The central question is simple to state and hard to answer: when a mid-size city loosens density rules, who stays and who is pushed out? I break this into three sub-questions.

- Does upzoning in a corridor precede a rise in market-rate permits within two years?
- Is that permit activity associated with higher tenant turnover in adjacent blocks?
- Do anti-displacement provisions, where present, change the pattern?

2. Motivation

Housing scholarship often studies large coastal cities, where the politics and the data are both unusual. Mid-size cities are where most Americans actually live the housing question, and their zoning fights are quieter but no less consequential. Worcester, MA and New Haven, CT offer a useful contrast: both have revised zoning since 2022, but they differ in the strength of their tenant protections.

3. Literature and Prior Work

This proposal continues a line of work I began under Dr. James Whitmore. My junior paper (reference P10, grade A-) found a weak but persistent association between corridor upzoning and permit activity. It also exposed a measurement problem: turnover is easy to count and hard to attribute. The thesis addresses that problem directly. Key sources are tracked in workbook X04. The most load-bearing are listed below.

Ref	Author	Year	Contribution
S01	Rothstein	2017	Legal history of exclusionary zoning
S03	MA DHCD	2024	Worcester housing production data
S04	New Haven	2023	Local affordable housing update
S09	Marsh	2025	Mid-size reform framework
S10	Whitmore	2021	Displacement metric critique

4. Data and Methods

4.1 Data Sources

- Parcel-level zoning and permit records from each city's planning department.
- American Community Survey five-year estimates for rent burden and tenure (S08).
- HUD comprehensive affordability data for cross-checks (S06).
- A hand-coded register of anti-displacement provisions by corridor.

4.2 Method

I will build a corridor-level panel for 2018 through 2025 and estimate a difference-in-differences specification comparing upzoned corridors to matched comparison corridors. Standard errors will be clustered at the corridor level. The displacement index from P06 serves as a secondary outcome. All cleaning code will live in a versioned repository, and figures will be reproducible.

4.3 Limitations

- Permit timing is noisy and may lag zoning changes unevenly across cities.
- Turnover is a proxy for displacement, not a direct measure.
- Two cities cannot support strong external claims; the aim is depth, not breadth.

5. Timeline

Milestone	Target date	Deliverable
Proposal	2027-10-05	This document
Data assembled	2027-11-06	Clean corridor panel
Interim chapter	2027-12-04	Methods and first results (D02)
Full draft	2028-03-20	Complete manuscript
Defense	2028-04-24	Committee review
Final	2028-05-15	Submitted thesis

6. Committee

Advisor	Prof. Lena Marsh
Reader	Dr. James Whitmore
Department	Political Science
Thesis code	THS-PS-2028

7. Expected Contribution

If the analysis holds, the thesis offers mid-size city planners a clearer read on when upzoning needs paired tenant protections to avoid displacing the residents it is meant to help. Even a null result is useful: it would suggest that corridor upzoning, on its own, moves slower than the displacement debate assumes. Either way the work is honest about its limits and reproducible by anyone with the data.

9. Data Management Plan

All raw data will be stored in a single project folder with a dated subfolder per source pull. Cleaning steps are scripted, never manual, so the corridor panel can be rebuilt from raw files in one command. Personally identifying information is not used; all units are corridors or blocks, not households.

Asset	Storage	Backup	Retention
Raw source pulls	Project drive	Weekly	Through defense
Cleaning scripts	Versioned repo	On commit	Permanent
Corridor panel	Project drive	Weekly	Through defense
Figures	Versioned repo	On commit	Permanent

10. Budget and Resources

The thesis requires no cash budget beyond standard student resources. The main inputs are public data, advising time, and compute access through the course.

Resource	Source	Cost USD
Public permit and ACS data	City and Census	0
Compute for cleaning	Course cluster	0
Advising	Prof. Marsh office hours	0
Printing and binding	Personal	30 estimated

11. Ethics and Reproducibility

- No human subjects data; analysis is at the corridor level only.
- All code and data steps are documented for independent replication.
- Limitations are reported alongside results, not buried in footnotes.
- Sources are credited; the displacement index method is described in full (P06).

12. References

A full bibliography is maintained in the research vault and mirrored in workbook X04. Citations follow the department style guide.